

came back to their native places," he says. Most organisations had cut salaries and also disallowed overtime work, much favoured by emigrants, forcing them to head home. There has been a spurt in NRE deposits in past months, mainly on account of the transfer from overseas banks after many foreign banks faced collapse and also the rise in the value of dollar. The NRE deposits in Kerala banks which were Rs 31,865 crore in June 2008 are expected to cross Rs 35,000 crore by June this year. There is a huge rush for seats in schools from non-resident Keralite families as many plan to return for good after the academic year in their children's schools is over there. "All the seats for the next academic year beginning in June have been reserved by the end of January. This has never happened before," says Fr. Thomas Madakkal, principal of a local school in Pathanamthitta.

Non-resident Keralites are peeved at the state and Central governments for their lack of sincerity in grappling with this issue. "Both the state and Central governments do only lip service to the non-resident population. The rehabilitation package announced by the state is far from adequate," says K.K. Sarachandra Bose, a corporate lawyer in Dubai. According to him, the Indian embassies in the Gulf deliberately downplay the gravity of the problem to please the governments there and keep the business lobby in good humour. "The Gulf bubble has burst. It's like the economic world war of the century. It's like a black hole and we don't know the end of it." The embassies have been instructed not to speak on the



NRE deposits in Kerala banks are expected to cross Rs 35,000 crore by June this year.

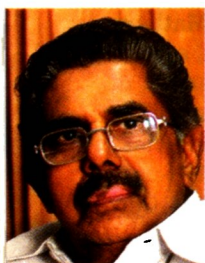
140 returned migrants committed suicide in Kerala last year.

THE RETURN OF EXPATRIATES WILL TURN INTO A FLOOD ONCE SCHOOLS CLOSE NEXT MONTH

recession. Even the media has been gagged in the Gulf. They have been asked to abstain from carrying stories relating to recession. Gulf-based journalists complain of punitive action against those publishing stories on recession. "There is an undeclared censorship," says a journalist from Dubai.

Many feel the returnees are faced with a bleak future back home. According to K.V. Shamsudheen of the Pravasi Bandhu Trust, non-residents have remitted more than Rs 2,00,000 crore to Kerala in the past 33 years. "Only 5 per cent of this amount has been utilised for productive investment. Most of the returnees have no savings as they spent their money on unproductive channels like buying big houses or expensive weddings. There has not been any rehabilitation package either for those who have forced to come back home", he says. According to him there has been a rise in the suicides by returned migrants, from 40 in 2003 to 140 last year. A study by the Centre for Development Studies notes that Kerala until 2007 had a million returnees from the Gulf.

With no jobs in hand, how many of them will be able to survive the slowdown is a big question. And unfortunately, there is no answer.



“There is a great dip in employment opportunities there. The number of group visas issued to Gulf countries fell from 2,286 in January 2008 to just 265 in December.”

VAYALAR RAVI, Minister of Overseas Indian Affairs